2.2 From Plantations to the Backcountry

There's a saying that "the rich get richer," and it seemed to be true on the large plantations. More land and slaves meant more cash crops—and more money.

MAIN IDEA Life in the coastal areas of the Southern Colonies differed greatly from life further inland, and revolved extensively around slavery.

WEALTH AND CLASS

Over time, wealthy planters in Maryland, Virginia, and the Carolinas bought more and more land and slaves. The expanding plantations produced increasing amounts of tobacco, rice, and indigo. The owners reaped the profits.

Not all farmers became wealthy, but the owners of the largest plantations became so wealthy and powerful that distinct classes formed among southern farmers. With their luxurious homes and leisurely lifestyle, rich landowners lived like nobles in Europe.

An army of slaves made this way of life possible. The work the slaves performed depended on where they lived. In South Carolina, each enslaved person received certain jobs to complete each day—a field to hoe, a fence to build. In the Chesapeake, most enslaved people worked on the plantation for a specific number of hours or until the **overseer**, or supervisor, told them to stop. As a result, many slaves worked long into the night.

While some plantation owners treated enslaved people fairly well, others did not. But the terrible workload took its toll on all the laborers. As work increased and the hours grew even longer, death rates among enslaved people surged dramatically.

THE BACKCOUNTRY

A different kind of culture arose as some settlers in the Southern Colonies sought their fortune in the backcountry. The **backcountry** stretched along the Appalachian Mountains from Pennsylvania south through the Shenandoah Valley to the Carolinas. This region included the rich soil, rolling hills, and deep forests of the **Piedmont**, a relatively flat area between the mountains and the coastal plain.

In the early 1700s, European settlers such as the Scots-Irish, immigrants from the northern part of Ireland, came to the colonies. They began settling in the backcountry and establishing farms outside the first English settlements, carving their farmland out of the forests.

Backcountry farmers learned to be self-sufficient. They used one of the most plentiful natural resources of this region—timber—to build simple log cabins. They hunted and raised enough crops and livestock to feed their families. Women in the backcountry worked in the home, the fields, and the wild. Many of them carried guns. Also, unlike many people in the Southern Colonies, most of the immigrants living in the backcountry didn't rely on slaves.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was the social structure like in the Chesapeake in the 1700s?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** How did work patterns differ for slaves in South Carolina and the Chesapeake?
3. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** How did the environment of the backcountry affect how the people settling there made a living?

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Shenandoah Valley

In the 1700s, Scots-Irish settlers who had come to Pennsylvania began moving into the Shenandoah Valley in present-day West Virginia and Virginia. The rich soil of the valley made it a dream for farming, and at the time, the Scots-Irish had little competition from other Europeans. They did, however, compete for the land with Native Americans who had long called the region home.



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